The Founder's Shelf

30 books, chosen for a Tamil Nadu business owner. Suresh Balachandar, Boss Your Business.

Every book here answers a question an owner asks about his own business. They are grouped by the question, not by subject, and they are ordered the way a business is diagnosed rather than the way a bookshop is arranged. The framework named under each one is the single idea worth carrying out of it.

This list is yours. If you have the evenings, buy them and read them. If the list alone is enough, keep it and we are done.

1 · The Owner

Am I the reason this business cannot grow?

1. Mindset, Carol S. Dweck. Fixed and growth mindset. Every family business has a second generation being told what it is not good at.
2. The ONE Thing, Gary Keller. The Focusing Question. For the owner drowning in 40 tasks, one question asked daily.
3. Act Like a Leader, Think Like a Leader, Herminia Ibarra. Outsight, and the 3 shifts. The founder who built the company cannot run the company. You act your way into a new identity.
4. The Right Kind of Wrong, Amy C. Edmondson. The blameworthy to praiseworthy spectrum. Ask a room what share of their failures deserve blame. They say 2 percent. Then ask what share gets treated that way.
5. Questions Are the Answer, Hal Gregersen. The Question Burst. The answer is in the question.

2 · Direction

Where do we play, and why would anyone choose us?

1. Blue Ocean Strategy, W. Chan Kim and Renee Mauborgne. Strategy Canvas, Four Actions, Three Tiers of Noncustomers. Every squeezed manufacturer believes his only move is to be cheaper. This says otherwise.
2. Better, Simpler Strategy, Felix Oberholzer Gee. The Value Stick. Raise willingness to pay or lower willingness to sell. Everything else is redistribution.
3. Competitive Strategy, Michael E. Porter. Five Forces. A job work supplier with one large buyer will recognise his own life in the chapter on buyer power.
4. The Three Box Solution, Vijay Govindarajan. Manage, forget, create. Box 2, selectively forgetting the past, is the succession conversation in disguise.
5. Business Model Generation, Osterwalder and Pigneur. The Business Model Canvas. Nine blocks on 1 page. Most owners have never once drawn their own business.

3 · Revenue

How do we sell without it depending on me?

1. SPIN Selling, Neil Rackham. Situation, Problem, Implication, Need payoff. Built on 35,000 recorded sales calls and the most directly usable book here for a B2B manufacturer.
2. The Ultimate Sales Machine, Chet Holmes. Dream 100 and the Buyer's Pyramid. Pick the 100 customers worth having and pursue them.
3. The Challenger Sale, Dixon and Adamson. Teach, tailor, take control. Why the relationship builder loses to the challenger in complex sales.
4. The Five Tool Negotiator, Russell Korobkin. The bargaining zone and the 5 tools. Manufacturers get squeezed on price every quarter and almost none have been taught to negotiate.
5. Predictable Revenue, Aaron Ross. Splitting the sales role. How selling stops being the owner's personal talent and becomes a process.

4 · Demand

Why do they not know we exist?

1. Building a StoryBrand, Donald Miller. The SB7 Framework. Seven parts, customer as hero, and the most immediately applicable marketing book for an owner who has never written a line of copy.
2. Breakthrough Advertising, Eugene M. Schwartz. Five Stages of Market Awareness. 60 years old and still the deepest thing written on the subject.
3. R.E.D. Marketing, Greg Creed and Ken Muench. Relevance, Ease, Distinctiveness. Written by the CEO and CMO of the group that owns KFC and Pizza Hut.
4. Contagious, Jonah Berger. STEPPS. Word of mouth is the only marketing most Tamil Nadu businesses have ever had. This explains how it works.
5. Value Proposition Design, Osterwalder, Pigneur, Bernarda and Smith. The Value Proposition Canvas. The fit between what you make and what they want.

5 · Money

Where is the cash going, and what should we charge?

1. Profit First, Mike Michalowicz. Allocate profit first, then spend. A cash system an owner can run from a bank account on a Saturday morning.
2. The 10 Rules of Highly Effective Pricing, Danilo Zatta. Value based pricing. Most pricing is cost plus a habit, and 1 percent of price moves profit further than anything else on this list.
3. Your Most Important Number, Lee Benson. One number, everyone knows it, everyone moves it. It cuts through the dashboard problem.
4. The Outsiders, William N. Thorndike. Capital allocation. Reinvest, distribute, buy or pay down. The question nobody asks a ₹10 crore owner.

5. The Psychology of Money, Morgan Housel. Behaviour over spreadsheets. Most business finance problems start with the owner's own relationship with money.

6 · The Machine

Will this run without me in the room?

1. Traction, Gino Wickman. The Six Key Components. The dominant operating system for a business of this size.
2. Rocket Fuel, Wickman and Winters. Visionary and Integrator. The second in command problem, named and solved.
3. Work the System, Sam Carpenter. Documenting the recurring processes. Unglamorous, and the reason you cannot take a holiday.
4. First, Break All the Rules, Buckingham and Coffman. The Q12. Managers, not companies, decide whether good people stay.
5. Scaling Up, Verne Harnish. The Four Decisions. People, Strategy, Execution, Cash, for a business crossing from owner run to management run.

What to do with this

Start with the question that is actually yours. Not the one that is most interesting. The one you avoid.

Read that block of 5 before you touch another. Five books held in 1 mental mode settle faster than 5 books across 5 subjects.

And if the evenings are not there, that is what Puthaga Paravai is for. I read the book. I take the 1 idea that changes a decision. I bring it to you in Tamil, set in a business like yours.

Suresh Balachandar

Boss Your Business, Chennai

the_coach@sureshbalachandar.in